over his frequent visits to US officials and keep New Delhi informed on all aspects of lobbying in those crazy days,' said Mathur, still barely able to control his anger towards the USA and particularly the CIA.

One of Aulakh's contacts, John Taylor Doolittle, a politician from California, frequently accused India of human rights violations. He referred to Punjab as Khalistan and believed that the USA should support the rights of the minority people of Khalistan, Kashmir and Nagaland to a free and fair vote on independence from India.

Mathur's case officer in Delhi, N. Vish-wanathan, was particularly worried by the propaganda unleashed by Sikh leaders abroad. In his own words, 'India was paying a huge price because some pathetic men sitting in air-conditioned rooms were exploiting flaws in youngsters.'

On a foggy morning in mid-December 1989, the top spies of the R&AW made their way to a glassed conference room that was regularly subjected to bug sweeping. Rajiv Gandhi had lost the election and V.P. Singh, riding on the popular anti-corruption sentiment, had captured the prime minister's seat at Raisina Hill. In Kashmir, the kidnapping of Rubaiya Sayeed, daughter of then Home Minister Mufti Mohammed Sayeed, jolted the security establishment. Meanwhile in Punjab, the over ground activities of pro-Khalistan supporters was gathering a pace that triggered another round of effective political lobbying abroad. In the meeting, Vishwanathan suggested a counteroffensive to eliminate the propagandists' network. He later recalled that the arguments were mostly focused on the US, but it was decided that something must be done before the virus spread and fanned international opinion against the Indian government.